

Of course, it doesn't just have to be lights. You can also expand this role to turning off unnecessary heating or air conditioning, closing doors when the aircon is on, or turning off leaky taps.

Yes, it saves you money . . . but it also teaches your kids' highly impressionable brains a few important lessons: that electricity isn't free, that saving money is important, and that they're expected to contribute to the effort (oh, and it's good for the planet).

And if you want, this can even be one of the jobs that your kids earn pocket money for.

Tweens: The petrol price game

My family and I live in the country, so by default we spend a lot of time in the car . . .

With three kids under the age of five.

If you're a parent, you know how painful that is.

'I spy with my little eye, something beginning with T,' sings my five-year-old from the back seat.

'Is it a . . . tree?'

'Yes!'

Then he starts again: 'I spy with my little eye, something beginning with . . . T.'

'It's a tree again, isn't it?'

'Yes!'

There's only so many times you can play this game before you want to swerve into oncoming traffic.

So instead I created the petrol price game, where the kids are always on the lookout to find the cheapest petrol prices. Of course, right now my kids are too young to really get the idea . . . they simply call out the numbers that